

Early Miner Leads Falter

By **TIM MORRIS**

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The University of Texas at El Paso baseball team got off to a couple of quick leads against Ranger Junior College here Friday, but in the end it was the Rangers who made an early evening of it as they swept the Miners 9-3 and 4-3 in a season-opening doubleheader.

UTEP grabbed a 3-1 lead in the second inning of the first game when catcher Jim Kennedy doubled home Terry Dillingham, Brad George and pitcher Wes Zotz. But the Miners couldn't hang on as the Rangers erupted for a six-run inning in the fifth to overtake the Miners in the first game played on UTEP's new field on the school's campus.

The Miners lost another lead in the second game but appeared to be making a comeback of their own in the sixth inning, trailing 4-3 with the bases loaded and two out, when the game was called because of darkness.

The two teams meet again Saturday in another doubleheader beginning at noon, an hour earlier than Friday's starting time.

"I hate like hell to lose to a junior college," Miner Coach Andy Cohen said after the second game was called at about 6:10 p.m. "But that's what we did. It looked like we might have a rally there at the end but rules are rules. I had agreed to call it at the end of five but we decided to go ahead and play one more. We just couldn't get it in. We'll start earlier Saturday."

Starting didn't seem to be as big a problem for the Miners as finishing was this time out. UTEP jumped on Ranger's Randy Larson for four hits and three runs in the first two innings of the opener before the former Burges prepster settled down to shut the Miners out on three hits the rest of the way.

Meanwhile, the Rangers were blasting Miner pitching for six hits in the fifth inning alone as 11 Ranger batters came to the plate against three UTEP hurlers.

The hits came fewer and farther between in the second game but UTEP catcher Jim Bradford made his count as he struck for the first homer in the cozy new park, rifling a solo shot over the left field fence in the second inning to give the Miners a 2-1 advantage.

But the Rangers came right back with a run in the third to tie the game, got another score in the fourth on Ken Millburger's wild pitch to take the lead and two more insurance runs in the fifth that proved to be just enough protection.

UTEP got the bases loaded in the short sixth on back-to-back singles by Orlando Cordova and Art Bravo and a Kennedy walk before Bradford pushed a run across on yet another walk issued by Craig Fisch.

Fisch missed with a curve on his first pitch to Terry Dillingham and Ranger Coach Bill Allen came off the bench to replace him, but the umpires decided to call it a day.